for not thinking ahead. Some participants, who were evidently not my fans, got a vicarious pleasure in rubbing it in. I kept silent for I did not want to blame anyone, much less Dhawan, who I considered the tallest figure in Indian space science.

When there seemed to be no end to the chorus, Rao stood up.

'Mr Nambi, may I ask you out of purely academic curiosity why you did not consider building a test stand for testing a multiple-engine configuration?

Before the question ended, there stood Dhawan with his hand raised. And there was pin-drop silence.

'Nambi had the foresight,' he said. 'He wanted to build a test stand for testing a four-engine cluster. It was I who stopped him. I was wrong.'

Dhawan could have kept silent and let me take the blame, for I would have never blamed anyone. But that was the integrity of the man. When Dhawan had completed his speech, there were no more questions on the subject. I did not feel proud of what Dhawan had said about my foresight. I felt sad that Dhawan had to own it up.